

CHAO-JEN WONG, PH.D.

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🏠 Seattle, Washington

Accomplished bioinformatician with 15+ years of experience in genomic data analysis, software development, and workflow engineering. Ph.D. in Applied Mathematics with expertise in computational genomics, epigenomics, statistical analysis, and pipeline development for NGS and long-read WGS data. Experienced in building reproducible, scalable, and portable genomic data ecosystems and integrating ML, AI, and LLM-assisted tools into bioinformatics workflows. Brings a change-ready mindset and the ability to adopt and apply new technologies to evolving scientific and computational challenges.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages: R (Package Development, Bioconductor), Python (Pandas, Scikit-Learn, TensorFlow), SQL, MATLAB, Bash

Workflows: Nextflow, Git, Docker/Singularity, AWS/EC2, HPC

Genomics: Fiber-seq, scRNA-seq, RNA-seq, ATAC-seq, ChIP-seq, CUT&RUN, Ribo-seq, DNA methylation, variant calling, proteomics

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Sr. Bioinformatician

Oct 2023 – Present

Seattle Children's Research Institute

- Architected and extended the open-source Nextflow nf-core/pacvar (v1.1.0) pipeline—a globally recognized, industry-grade workflow ecosystem trusted across pharma and academia—enabling comprehensive variant calling and multi-omic methylation profiling for PacBio long-read WGS data.
- Engineered and validated a clinical-grade PacBio long-read WGS diagnostic workflow for pediatric cancers and rare diseases, replacing a months-long battery of disparate assays with a single, same-day test that eliminated misdiagnoses, increased diagnostic yield, and enabled rapid, life-saving precision treatment.
- Uncovered the epigenetic adaptational landscape of sarcoma cells under BRD4 inhibition, identifying H3K27ac recruitment as the key mechanism triggering downstream mesenchymal shift and axonogenesis.
- Challenged a decades-old paradigm in cancer therapy by proving anthracyclines suppress aggressive leukemias through translation inhibition rather than DNA damage—a discovery enabled by integrating multi-omic and high-throughput drug screening datasets.
- Engineered custom R packages like talusR and peakable to automate proteomics profiling and CUT&RUN replicate validation, eliminating technical noise and preventing false-positive biological conclusions in multi-omic workflows.

Bioinformatician III

Oct 2015 – Jun 2023

Tapscott Lab, Human Biology Department, Fred Hutchinson Cancer Center

- Led data-driven research for a cross-functional initiative that discovered the primary disease progression mechanisms in facioscapulohumeral muscular dystrophy (FSHD), published in Human Molecular Genetics.
- Identified the first validated panels of gene signatures representing FSHD molecular activity, setting the industry standard for post-therapeutic clinical trial measurements.
- Pioneered research demonstrating immune cell infiltration in FSHD-affected muscle, shifting the scientific understanding of the disease's systemic progression.
- Founded and led a peer-to-peer data science community at Fred Hutch, growing membership from 32 to over 250 scientists within a year.

Bioinformatics Analyst II

Oct 2011 – Oct 2015

Grady Lab, Clinical Research Division, Fred Hutch Cancer Center

- Contributed to the first published study reporting human colon DNA methylation profiles and subtype classification in colon adenocarcinoma, using Illumina 450K array-based methylation profiling.

- Collaborated on two peer-reviewed studies on DNA methylation-based modeling of the human biological clock and epidemiologic analysis of cigarette smoking associations with prostate cancer outcomes.

Bioconductor Core Developer

Sep 2008 – Sep 2011

Gentleman Lab, Computational Biology Program, Fred Hutchinson Cancer Center

- Contributed to the core infrastructure of Bioconductor for genomic data analysis and visualization.
- Developed novel algorithms for multi-channel flow cytometry normalization using functional data analysis.
- Served as a lead reviewer for 50+ Bioconductor package submissions, enforcing rigorous standards for statistical validity and software quality.

Postdoctoral Researcher

Aug 2007 – May 2008

San Diego State University

- Research fields included numerical methods for solving partial differential equations and microarray analysis investigating associations between antidiabetic medications and cardiovascular disease.

Analytic Consultant

Apr 2006 – Jan 2007

Pacific Nanotechnology (Contract)

- Developed atomic force microscopy tip deconvolution and image reconstruction algorithms to correct imaging artifacts caused by imperfect probe-tip geometry, resulting in a peer-reviewed publication.

Academic Part-Time Engineer

Apr 2000 – Sep 2005

Jet Propulsion Laboratory

- Developed high-fidelity Telecom Forecaster Predictor (TFP) software in MATLAB to simulate deep-space communication links for NASA JPL missions, including the Mars Exploration Rovers Spirit and Opportunity.
- Co-authored volumes in JPL's Deep Space Communications and Navigation Center of Excellence (DESCANSO) book series.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. & M.S. in Mathematics

2001 – 2006

Claremont Graduate University

Relevant coursework: statistical inference, time series analysis, and partial differential equations.

Thesis: Simulation of Immobilized Enzyme Kinetics and Transport in Sessile Hydrogen Drops. Adviser: Ali Nadim.

M.A. & B.A. in Applied Mathematics

1996 – 2000

California State University, Fullerton

RECENT PUBLICATIONS

- Sadeeshkumar H, Wong CJ, et al. Anthracyclines target the chromatin-translation axis independent of DNA damage. Manuscript under review at *Nature*.
- Wong CJ, et al. Regional and bilateral MRI and gene signatures in facioscapulohumeral dystrophy. *Human Molecular Genetics*. 2024;33(8):698-708.
- Hamm DC, Paatela EM, Bennett SR, Wong CJ, et al. The transcription factor DUX4 orchestrates translational reprogramming. *PLOS Biology*. 2023;21(9):e3002317.
- Wong CJ, et al. Canine DUXC: implications for DUX4 retrotransposition and preclinical models of FSHD. *Human Molecular Genetics*. 2022;31(10):1694-1704.

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

- Nextflow Ambassador, 2026.
- Poster presenter, Nextflow Summit Boston, 2026.
- Contributor to nf-core and participant in Nextflow Hackathons, 2024-2026.

COURSERA CERTIFICATIONS

- Sequence Models (DeepLearning.AI)
- Convolutional Neural Networks (DeepLearning.AI)
- Neural Networks and Deep Learning (DeepLearning.AI)
- Applied Machine Learning in Python (U. Michigan)
- SQL Basics for Data Science Specialization (UC Davis)